

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Disagree with the idea -> Stay curious -> No dismissal signals

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before disagreeing, check your face and tone. Remove any dismissal — eye-roll, sigh, 'obviously', sarcasm. Then disagree with the position, not the person.

BEST FOR

- High-stakes disagreements where the relationship must stay intact
- Peer-to-peer pushback in professional settings
- Disagreeing with someone more senior without damaging the relationship
- Debates where you are likely to be wrong about something

PHRASE BANK

Disagreement Openers · Stating the difference without contempt

- "I see this differently — my view is..."
- "I do not think that is quite right, and here is why."
- "I want to push back on one specific part of that."
- "I disagree, and I want to explain my reasoning."
- "That is not how I read the situation — here is my read."
- "I would reach a different conclusion from the same data."
- "I think there is a better option, and I want to explain why."
- "I have a different view on this, and I think it matters."

Curiosity Phrases · Staying open while disagreeing

- "Help me understand how you got there."
- "I want to make sure I am disagreeing with what you actually said."
- "Is there something I am missing that would change my view?"
- "Walk me through the part I am not seeing."
- "I might be wrong — what would change your position?"
- "I want to understand your reasoning before I push back harder."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Dismissive sigh, eye-roll, or 'obviously not'
Better: I do not think that is the right approach.
Best: I disagree — and I want to explain my reasoning.
2. Weak: Aggressive disagreement: 'That is completely wrong'
Better: I do not agree with that conclusion.
Best: I reach a different conclusion. Here is what I am seeing.
3. Weak: Disguised contempt: 'Well, I suppose if you want to look at it that way...'
Better: There are other ways to look at this.
Best: Direct disagreement with no passive-aggressive framing.

DECISION TREE

If You disagree strongly and feel contempt rising

Pause. Separate the idea from the person. Then respond.

"I want to be direct about this without being dismissive."

If The other person is using contempt on you

Name it calmly without matching it.

"I notice that landed with some edge. I would rather talk about the actual issue."

If You disagree but are not sure you are right

Disagree tentatively. Stay curious.

"I think this is wrong, but I want to understand your reasoning before I say that more firmly."

If The disagreement is personal as well as professional

Separate the professional point from the personal dimension explicitly.

"I want to keep this on the work question, not on the personal level."

If You have been right about this before and feel vindicated

Be careful. Contempt creeps in through 'told you so' energy.

"I think this confirms the concern I raised. I am not saying I was right — I am saying the data suggests..."

SCENARIOS

Colleague proposes an approach you think is flawed

Name the disagreement specifically. Stay on the idea. — "I think there is a problem with the approach, and I want to name it clearly."

Senior person makes a claim you believe is incorrect

Disagree respectfully on the substance, not the status. — "I want to respectfully push back on that — the data I have seen suggests otherwise."

Debate where emotions are running high

Slow down. Remove contempt signals. State disagreement plainly. — "I disagree with that and I want to explain why — without this getting heated."

You realise mid-disagreement you might be wrong

Say so. It builds more credibility than pressing on. — "Actually — hold on. I want to reconsider that."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person's position is genuinely harmful and requires sharp, unambiguous challenge — softness can imply tacit endorsement.
- In high-stakes negotiations where tactical firmness is operationally necessary.
- When you have already tried respectful disagreement repeatedly and the priority is clarity over tone.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Contempt audit

Notice every time you feel contempt in a conversation today — even mild contempt. Do not act — just notice.

Day 2 — Separate idea from person

In one disagreement, consciously target the idea not the person. Notice the difference.

Day 3 — Remove dismissal signals

Eliminate sighs, eye-rolls, 'obviously', and sarcasm from one disagreement today.

Day 4 — Stay curious

After disagreeing, ask one genuine question about their reasoning.

Day 5 — Direct disagreement practice

State one disagreement plainly using 'I disagree because...' with no softening or hedging.

Day 6 — High-stakes practice

Use this in one real disagreement that matters — with a colleague, manager, or partner.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your disagreements stay productive? Did the relationships hold? Was anything lost by being more direct?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I disagree with the idea, not the person?
- Did I remove contempt signals — tone, face, word choice?
- Did I state the disagreement plainly rather than hiding it?
- Did I stay curious about their reasoning?
- Did I avoid sarcasm, eye-rolls, and dismissive language?
- Did I stay on the substance of the disagreement?
- Did the relationship remain intact after the disagreement?
- Did I consider that I might be wrong?